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Pacific slopes lie in
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worry,' said Daniel,
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A Our next stop was on neither of these, however, but in the misty highlands that divide them. We drove up a hairpin ascent to Costa Rica's highest active volcano. On a good day, you can see both coasts from here. We had no such luck, but the swirling mist allowed glimpses into the flooded crater.

B Still, an early start is no bad thing. So far, we've needed every minute of daylight to get through our breathless itinerary, and our time at this guest house promises to be the most action-packed yet.

C That evening, inspired by what we'd seen, we cooked our own Costa Rican meal. Our hosts provided ingredients and instructions, and then kept a discreet distance as we sliced, mashed, drizzled and seasoned to produce our best shot at a traditional supper.

D But you don't need a guide to find Costa Rica's wildlife. In fact, you don't even need to go looking for it. So exuberant is nature in this part of the world that wild creatures form an unavoidable backdrop to whatever else you might get up to.

E The next morning, with these anxieties having proved unfounded, we wound further down through the coffee plantations in the sunshine to the estate of Tayutic. Here, my daughter helped to sort good macadamia nuts from bad as they rattled down the chute, then attempted to crush dried coffee beans in a stone mill.

F Admittedly, this would feel even more daunting if we hadn't done this already a few days ago, on the slopes of Arenal Volcano. Then, I found it terrifying, hurtling at unnatural speeds high above the canopy. Now I'm a little more confident.

G But before I can glory in my success, we're making our way to a hot springs resort, the penultimate stop on our two-week Costa Rican adventure tour. Like the other volcanoes we've seen in the country, the one near here belches sulphurous smoke.